

Supporting Non-Native Speakers with Faroese Language Learning Through a Mobile Application

Background

The low availability of language resources for the Faroese language affects not only native speakers but also newcomers who are learning Faroese as a second language, making the integration process slower and more challenging. Recent changes in migration patterns and arrival of Ukrainian Refugees to the Faroe Islands have changed the landscape in the Islands call for a urgent development of tools that aid in the language learning processes of the newcomers. For this reason, there is a growing need to make Faroese language learning more accessible.

Mobile applications offer an interactive and user-friendly approach to language learning that can support traditional methods for language learning, offering an opportunity to address the problem from a new perspective. Therefore, we aim at developing a proof-of-concept mobile application aimed at assisting individuals in learning Faroese as a second language. The app will leverage a dataset of Faroese short stories and their translations to craft basic games that reinforce language acquisition.

The project will be co-supervised by the Refugee Coordinator of Torshavn's municipality and Red Cross' Language café project coordinator, Sylvia Magnussen. Her insights will guide the direction and ensure the applicability of the project for its intended audience.

Key objectives

1. Data-Driven Learning:
 - Use a curated dataset of short Faroese stories written in simple language with day-to-day vocabulary.
 - Extract sentences from these stories to craft educational games.
2. Educational Games:
 - Translation Matching: Match Faroese sentences or words with their correct English translations.
 - Sentence Construction: Given an English translation, pick the right Faroese words and arrange them to construct the corresponding sentence and vice versa.

Possible Extensions (Subject to Time Constraints) include:

1. Grammar Games: Challenge users to select the correctly inflected form of a word based on a given context.
2. Text-to-Speech Feature: Introduce a function allowing users to hear the correct pronunciation of words.

The application will prioritize user-friendliness, ensuring that users of all tech proficiencies can navigate and benefit from it. A visually appealing layout will enhance the overall learning experience and keep users engaged.

Community Engagement and Feedback Collection:

Post-development, the application will be tested by the local community of Faroese language learners (Málkafe, Red Cross). One of the primary objectives post-launch will be to administer surveys and gather user feedback. This feedback will provide valuable insights into potential areas of improvement, ensuring that the application remains relevant and effective.

Conclusion:

This project aims to provide a first step towards technological support to Faroese language learning. This application will not only make the process of learning Faroese more engaging but also more accessible to newcomers, helping them integrate better into the Faroese community.